THE RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR

THE RUSSIAN AND JAPANESE EMPIRES went to war in 1904 over their rival ambitions in northern China and Korea. In the naval war, the Japanese were from the outset more aggressively led and better trained and motivated than their opponents. The Russians also suffered from the dispersal of their naval forces—the squadrons in Port Arthur and Vladivostok never succeeded in joining up, and when the Baltic fleet was sent on an epic voyage around the world to the Pacific in 1905, it was crushingly defeated at Tsushima. The victory for an Asiatic over a European power upset assumptions of white racial superiority. Japan gained control of Port Arthur and soon took over Korea. The Japanese were confirmed as valuable allies for Britain in the Pacific, while defeat plunged Russia into the 1905 revolution that the tsarist regime barely survived.



THE RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR 1904–1905

The main areas of operations during the Russo-Japanese War were the Korean and Liaodong peninsulas, southern Manchuria, and the seas around Japan and Korea. The Russians were particularly keen to control the warm-water Pacific port of Port Arthur—the other main Russian port on the Pacific, Vladivostok, was inaccessible during winter months.

KEY

- Japan
- Russia
- To Russia 1897, to Japan 1905
- Area leased to Japan 1895
- Japanese advance/ landing
- Route of Russian Baltic fleet 1905
- Japanese victory

THE BATTLE OF PORT ARTHUR

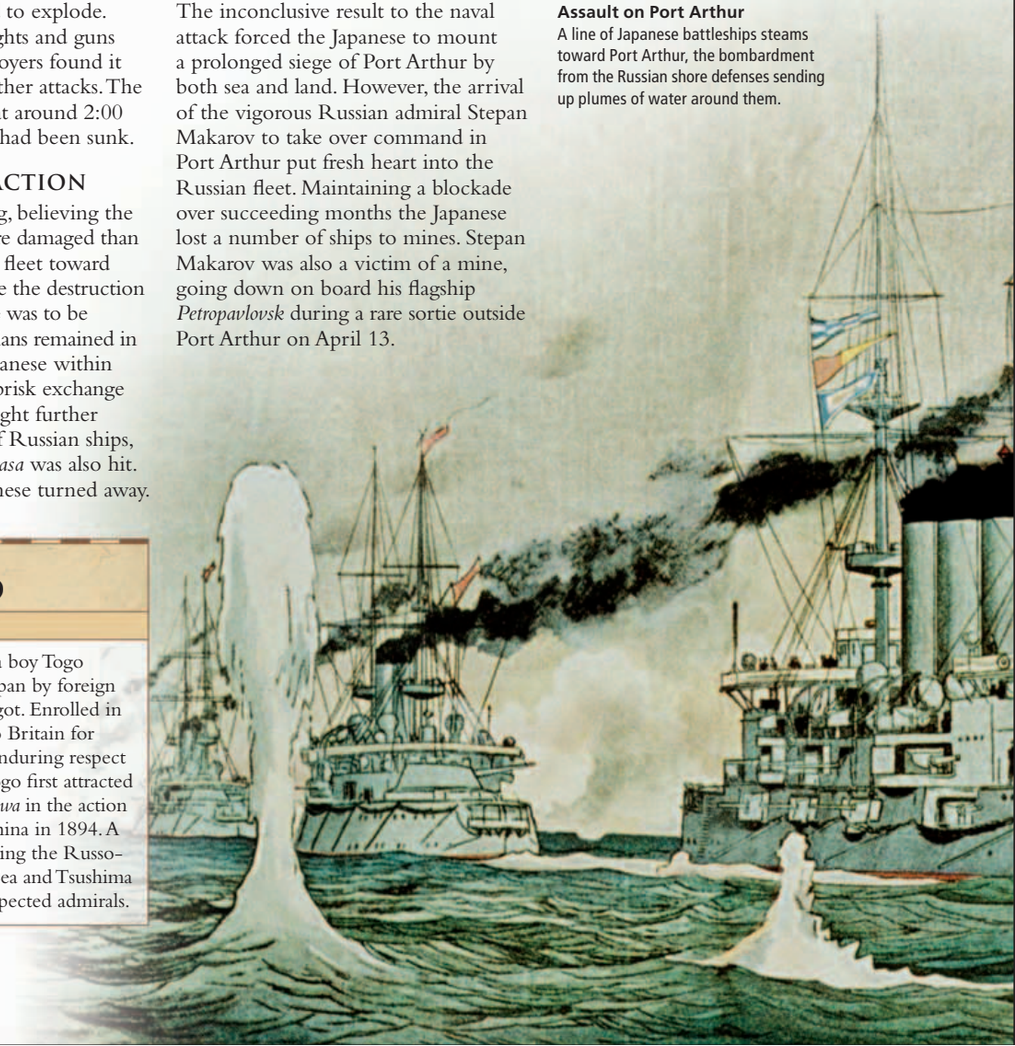
The Russian First Pacific Squadron in harbor at Port Arthur was a potential threat that Japan decided to eliminate at the outset of hostilities. Admiral Togo planned to launch a night attack that would enjoy total surprise since it would precede a declaration of war.

An attack squadron of 10 Japanese destroyers armed with Whitehead torpedoes reached Port Arthur shortly after midnight on February 8. Most of the Russian fleet was lit up, as was the town behind it. Confusion and terror followed as torpedoes exploded against the hulls of the American-built pre-dreadnought *Retvizan* and the protected cruiser *Pallada*. The battleship *Tsesarevich* was also hit. But the operation was less effective than Togo had hoped. Many torpedoes were caught in Russian torpedo nets and failed to explode. Once Russian searchlights and guns were manned the destroyers found it hard to press home further attacks. The action was broken off at around 2:00 a.m. No Russian ships had been sunk.

THE DAYLIGHT ACTION

The following morning, believing the Russian ships were more damaged than they were, Togo led his fleet toward Port Arthur to complete the destruction of the Russian fleet. He was to be disappointed. The Russians remained in harbor, drawing the Japanese within range of shore guns. A brisk exchange of long-range fire brought further damage to a number of Russian ships, but Togo's flagship *Mikasa* was also hit. After an hour the Japanese turned away.

The inconclusive result to the naval attack forced the Japanese to mount a prolonged siege of Port Arthur by both sea and land. However, the arrival of the vigorous Russian admiral Stepan Makarov to take over command in Port Arthur put fresh heart into the Russian fleet. Maintaining a blockade over succeeding months the Japanese lost a number of ships to mines. Stepan Makarov was also a victim of a mine, going down on board his flagship *Petropavlovsk* during a rare sortie outside Port Arthur on April 13.



Assault on Port Arthur
A line of Japanese battleships steams toward Port Arthur, the bombardment from the Russian shore defenses sending up plumes of water around them.



1848–1934

TOGO HEIHACHIRO

FLEET-ADMIRAL OF THE IMPERIAL JAPANESE NAVY

Born into the Satsuma samurai clan, as a boy Togo Heihachiro witnessed the bullying of Japan by foreign naval forces, a humiliation he never forgot. Enrolled in the fledgling Imperial Navy, he went to Britain for training in 1871 and brought back an enduring respect for the traditions of the Royal Navy. Togo first attracted attention as captain of the cruiser *Naniwa* in the action at Asan that opened the war with China in 1894. A calm and confident commander during the Russo-Japanese War, victories at the Yellow Sea and Tsushima made him one of the world's most respected admirals.